

up with Ho Chi Minh and other Vietnamese nationalists. Giap secretly returned to Vietnam to organize the Viet Minh spy network, establish a paramilitary force, and start a propaganda campaign against the Japanese-supported government.

With the end of World War II, which halted the negotiations with France for independence, Giap and the Viet Minh launched a decade-long struggle to oust their colonial adversaries. Showing a natural flair for guerrilla tactics, Giap took the fight to the French.

Tactical brilliance

As a military strategist, Giap was adept at compelling the opposing army to divide its forces into smaller units spread across a huge area, which could then be isolated and attacked with force. Giap's *coup de grâce* was the 1954 battle against the French at Dien Bien Phu, where he achieved a decisive victory with his unconventional battlefield tactics.

With this experience under his belt, Giap questioned the plan for the 1968 Tet Offensive, during which the North Vietnamese Army (NVA) and Viet Cong forces struck more than 100 enemy targets on the same day. Events proved that Giap's doubts were correct. Communist troops lost on the field of battle, though Hanoi emerged as victors in the propaganda struggle that followed. As the senior general of the NVA, Giap was a national hero and would have the honor of issuing the final orders of the 1975 Spring Offensive that would retake Saigon and reunify Vietnam.



His greatest victory

Giap's 1954 victory at Dien Bien Phu is depicted in this propaganda painting on the walls of the old fort, where the French held out for 57 days before surrendering to the Viet Minh.